community obligations. Excavated inscriptions show, for instance, that after Ashoka's demise, monastic life at Sanchi was sustained much less by royal patronage and far more by lay donors, including many women.[26] According to archaeologist scholar Lars Fogelin:

> As the [monastic] *sangha* progressively withdrew from regular contact with the laity in the first millennium CE, the laity returned the favor, shifting their devotions to rival religious orders. This shift was facilitated by the incorporation of Buddhist architectural, ritual, and doctrinal elements by rival religious sects . . . the laity increasingly found the rites and rituals of nascent Hinduism and other sects more satisfying . . . By the end of the first millennium CE the laity had abandoned Buddhism throughout most of India.[27]

'The decline of Buddhism in the Ganges heartland and the peninsula occurred before the Turkish conquest,' writes Thapar.[28] Both Buddhism and Brahminism required royal patronage, but kings were shifting to an exclusively Brahminical ideology. Excluding the Palas, the new dynasties that arose in the last quarter of the first millennium—such as the Karkotas, Pratiharas, Chandelas, Rashtrakutas, Pandyas and Pallavas—were all Brahminical with little or no affinity for Buddhism. In the central Indian region that became the realm of the Chandelas (831–1308), Buddhism and its monastic orders had almost entirely disappeared—after once thriving there under the Mauryas (builders of Sanchi and Bharhut), the Guptas and Harsha.[29]

The Palas were the last major Buddhist dynasty in India, but they'd been gone for nearly a century when the Turkish conquerors arrived, c. 1200 CE. Bengal and Bihar were then ruled by the orthodox Brahminical Sena Dynasty, which had introduced Kulinism, or supremacist caste rules in society, and had begun persecuting Buddhists, causing many of them to flee Bengal.[30] 'When the Muslim invasions came,' writes scholar Gail Omvedt, 'the final blow was dealt to this nearly vanished Buddhism, vulnerable because of its lack of support in the life of the people and its centralization in the monasteries.'[31]

In time, without followers or patrons, Buddhist sites in eastern India too fell into ruin or were occupied by other religious orders. For instance, the Mahabodhi Temple at Bodh Gaya was turned into a Shiva temple; the bricks of Uddandapura were recycled for an Islamic mausoleum. By the mid-second millennium, Fogelin writes, 'only vestiges of Buddhism